

245 Small Business Strategy Team

(formerly 510)

Description & Eligibility

Teams will analyze a real-world small business case and develop data-driven, strategic solutions to address identified challenges. Using critical thinking and collaborative problem-solving skills, teams will prepare and present an action plan with recommendations addressing financial, operational, human resource, and marketing impacts. At the state and national levels, teams will receive an additional scenario element requiring rapid analysis and revision of their strategy before final presentation. Any secondary or postsecondary division contestant may enter this judged team event. A team will consist of 2-4 contestants. Teams must be registered for the national competition before the submission deadline and compete in both parts of the event to be ranked. Entries that do not follow the provided topic or the Copyright and/or Fair Use Guidelines and the Artificial Intelligence Usage & Citation Policy will be disqualified.

Topic

SmartNest Dynamics, founded by Evan Harper, is a smart-home installation and support company that has grown steadily over the past three years. The team installs smart lighting, climate control, security systems, entertainment setups, and whole-home automation for homes and small offices in a fast-growing suburban metro area. Known for reliable, high-quality service, SmartNest Dynamics is typically booked 2-3 weeks out, and subscription services now make up 40% of revenue. The company currently has six installers and two support staff.

Even with strong demand, Evan is reaching a turning point. SmartNest Dynamics is busier than ever and keeping up is difficult. Heavy installer workloads, rising support requests, and Evan's responsibilities with scheduling, communication, training, and inventory make planning ahead challenging. Meanwhile, new opportunities—smart-office installations, AI-powered features, and subscription growth—are emerging, but current systems and staffing may not fully support a large expansion.

Evan hopes to grow SmartNest Dynamics sustainably—improving operations, exploring new technology options, and maintaining the company's strong reputation. He has hired your team to recommend a strategic growth plan for the coming year.

Your plan should include:

- Key actions SmartNest Dynamics should take to support sustainable growth
- Recommendations to improve staffing, workflow, or daily operations
- A decision on whether SmartNest Dynamics should begin offering AI-based smart-home features this year
- Ways to strengthen customer satisfaction and overall service quality

Considerations:

- Which growth opportunity SmartNest Dynamics should prioritize first
- How day-to-day operations can be streamlined as demand increases
- What factors SmartNest Dynamics should evaluate before introducing AI-powered features

Team Must Supply

- For each round of presentations (preliminaries and finals) the team must provide one (1) copy of the Works Cited formatted according to the *Style & Reference Manual*, signed BPA Release Form(s), and AI Usage and Documentation Form
- Sharpened pencils, pens
- Optional (Prep Room Only) – Laptop/notebook computer, portable printer with paper (1 per team)
 - AI Policy Level 1 *No AI Allowed*

- Students may use one single-sided laptop, notebook, or tablet for their presentation. Projection equipment and external displays will not be provided or permitted.
- Optional - Prepared posters, graphs, poster board, flip charts and markers, product props (samples and promotional items)

Contest Notes

- Method of evaluation: judged
- AI Policy Level 2 *Permitted with Citation*
- Carry-in and setup of equipment must be done solely by the contestant within the time allotted
- No internet access will be provided on-site at the NLC. Contestants may bring their own internet access, but it may be used only during their presentation – not in the prep room.
- No materials may be left with the judges
- Length of the event: no more than five (5) minutes orientation and no more than thirty (30) minutes preparation time for state and national levels. No more than three (3) minutes setup, no more than ten (10) minutes for the presentation, and no more than ten (10) minutes judges' questions
- Each state is allowed three (3) entries

Contest Competencies

1. Develop and implement a strategic action plan, effectively managing time, finances, and personnel to achieve measurable outcomes
2. Apply entrepreneurial, managerial, and problem-solving principles to address business challenges and develop innovative solutions
3. Interpret and communicate data-driven insights, identifying key issues, assumptions, and evidence to support business recommendations
4. Conduct financial and situational analyses using SWOT, forecasting, and other strategic tools to evaluate short- and long-term impacts
5. Analyze team strengths, define roles, and delegate responsibilities to meet project goals
6. Deliver a persuasive, data-supported team presentation using clear visuals and appropriate digital tools
7. Apply ethical, legal, and socially responsible decision-making in all business recommendations
8. Use digital collaboration and productivity tools to plan, analyze, and present business solutions
9. Evaluate business strategies using KPIs and analytics to measure performance and guide decisions
10. Use innovation and change-management principles to create and implement effective business solutions

Contest Specifications for this Event

- At the state and national levels, teams will be given an additional element to the original scenario to address during the presentation. These added elements are specific to the level of competition and are not connected to or carried over from previous competitions.
- No personal electronic devices (smart watches, smart glasses, cell phone, etc.) other than the laptop, notebook, or tablet approved for the presentation.
- No advisor contact will be allowed between the time of receiving the additional element and the delivery.
- The team is responsible for securing a signed BPA Release Form(s) from any person, including themselves, whose image or work is used in the project.
- The team is responsible for citing all sources, including oneself, on the Works Cited page for any work used on the project. It is the policy of Business Professionals of America to comply with copyright law. The *Style & Reference Manual* contains guidelines for Copyright and/or Fair Use. Contestants will be disqualified for violations of the guidelines.
- Materials must follow the organization's BPA Graphic Standards and make proper use of the BPA logo and/or organization's name. Refer to the BPA Graphic Standards in the *Style & Reference Manual*.
- Judges' comments will be returned digitally through the online judging system at the national level. Materials submitted for technical judging will *not* be returned and will *not* be available at NLC.

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Presentation Scoring Rubric

Required Elements (If any question results in a NO, please assign a score of 0)				
Team followed the topic.				☐ Y ☐ N
Team followed the Copyright and/or Fair Use Guidelines and Artificial Intelligence Usage & Citation Policy.				☐ Y ☐ N
If answered no to either question, please stop scoring and provide a brief reason for the <i>disqualification</i> :				
Evaluation Criteria	Below Expectations 0-5 points	Meets Expectations 6-10 points	Above Expectations 11-15 points	Points Awarded
Delivery & Engagement	Team rarely maintains eye contact, uses minimal gestures and body language, or has significant inconsistencies in tone and pace.	Team occasionally breaks eye contact, uses limited gestures and body language, or has some inconsistencies in tone and pace.	Team maintains good eye contact, uses appropriate gestures and body language, and varies their tone and pace adequately.	/15
*Inclusion of On-Site Information	Did not incorporate additional information or made minimal adjustments.	Some responses lack detail or clarity. The understanding of the topic is partially demonstrated.	Responses are detailed, insightful, and effectively address the judges' questions.	/15
Evaluation Criteria	Below Expectations 0-10 points	Meets Expectations 11-24 points	Above Expectations 25-35 points	Points Awarded
Content Knowledge	Presentation demonstrates a limited understanding of the topic and includes mostly irrelevant or inaccurate information.	Presentation demonstrates a basic understanding of the topic and includes a mix of relevant and irrelevant information.	Presentation demonstrates a good understanding of the topic and includes relevant and accurate information.	/35
Evaluation Criteria	Below Expectations 0-4 points	Meets Expectations 5-7 points	Above Expectations 8-10 points	Points Awarded
Organization, Design & Structure	Presentation lacks coherence, and it is unclear how each team member's role contributes to the presentation. Transitions between speakers and/or points are awkward or absent.	Presentation content has some gaps, and it is not always clear how each team member's role contributes to the presentation. Transitions between speakers and/or points are choppy.	Presentation content flows adequately, and each team member's role is clear and integrated into the presentation. Transitions between speakers and/or points are smooth.	/10
Judges' Questions	Responses lack depth and fail to demonstrate a comprehensive understanding of the topic.	Some responses lack detail or clarity. The understanding of the topic is partially demonstrated.	Responses are detailed, insightful, and effectively address the judges' questions.	/10
Team Members	At least two original team members were present during the presentation.			/5
Timing & Documentation	Setup lasted no longer than three (3) minutes, and the presentation lasted no more than ten (10) minutes. One (1) copy of the Works Cited, BPA Release Form(s) and the AI Usage and Documentation Form for each round of the event (preliminary and final) was submitted.			/10
TOTAL PRESENTATION POINTS				/100

Props and/or additional items shall not be used as a basis for scoring.

*If there is no additional element, do not score this criterion.

PRESENTATION WILL BE STOPPED AT TEN (10) MINUTES